



cathartic for an entire people. When the feeble 'Indira Hatao' infuriated her, she came out with 'Garibi Hatao', an empty slogan but the most seductive one. When she was the target, she made her antagonists look silly, as if targeting her was as treacherous as targeting India. In retrospect, it was an exaggerated sense of her destiny as the infallible one—as infallible as India—that brought out the totalitarian temptations of Indira. The Emergency was the manifestation of the paranoia of the deified. She needed an enemy to further the myth of the protective goddess in the age of what her father would have called "storm and trouble". She would be humbled—or humanised. She would regain India, and finally, walk toward the waiting assassins.

Today, we get a glimpse of that starched cotton sari and brisk walk. And the new Mrs G is the most powerful politician in India, that too without being officially in power. She is winning the elections too. Then why is it that the original still concentrates the national mind? There was no middle ground for Indira, and no triangulations when action was needed. Lohia's "dumb doll" would become the ruthless, charismatic, and unforgiving practitioner of power. India overlooked her flaws and frailties because people could never differentiate between her political interest and the larger national interest. On the day before her assassination, she spoke at an election rally in Bhubaneswar: "I'm here today, I may not be here tomorrow. I do not care whether I live or die. I have lived a long life and I am proud that I spent the whole of my life in the service of my people... and when I die, every drop of my blood will invigorate India and strengthen it." Those were the words of a leader who believed that she had an emotional covenant with the people. She is still here today because those who are marketing her martyrdom or copying her style have not discovered the India that romanced Indira. The meek can never inherit Indira. They can only parody her. ■